The Logics of Violence:
Rebels, Criminal Groups, and the State
Fall 2025
Professor: Beatriz Magaloni
e-mail: magaloni@stanford.edu
Class Tuesday and Thursday Tue- Thu 3:00 - 4:20 PM
Wallenberg Hall 160-328

Office Hours:
Thursdays 4:30-6:00 pm (sign up)

This course delves into the complex and multifaceted topic of violence, examining its causes, organization, and consequences in society. Students will investigate key questions such as: What triggers violence? Who participates in it, and why? How are violent actions and movements structured and organized? What relationships develop between violent groups and civilian populations? And how do governments and institutions respond to, counter, or perpetuate violence? The course covers a broad spectrum of violence, including but not limited to civil wars, violent crime, and police repression. These forms of violence will be analysed from multiple perspectives, offering students a comprehensive understanding of their origins, dynamics, and impacts. In addition to theoretical frameworks, students will engage with empirical data and real-world examples to understand how violence manifests in different contexts and the challenges it poses to societies.

Course Requirements:

Preparation and Participation (20%): Students are expected to complete all assigned readings before class and come prepared to actively engage in discussions.

Reading Responses (20%) (1000 words): Students may enrol in the course for 3, 4, or 5 units, which determines their workload for reading responses: 3 units (one reading response); 4 units (two reading responses); 5 units (three reading responses). To be uploaded to canvas one day before the corresponding class discussion. Students writing on that week are expected to help lead our class discussion.

Peer Engagement: All students are required to read and review the reading responses of their peers before the seminar meets.

Case Study Presentation (20%): Each student will join a group of 2-3 students to present a case study on a country-specific conflict. Presentations will take place during two different days in class days (Nov 11) and (Dec 4). A sign-up sheet will be provided for students to choose their topics.

Movies and movie review (10%): Students will be watching various movies during class on civil wars and conflicts and deliver a one-page critical summary of the movie.

Final Examination (30%): A take-home exam will be distributed during Week 10, with submissions due during the final exam week. The number of questions students must answer corresponds to their enrolled units: 1 question (3 units), 2 questions (4 units) and 3 questions (5 units).

Readings:

All required and recommended readings are available electronically through Stanford libraries and will also be in the Canvas.

1. Introduction

2. Causes of Civil Wars (Sep 25)

Fearon, James D., and David D. Laitin. "Ethnicity, insurgency, and civil war." *American Political Science Review* 97, no. 01 (2003): 75-90.

Cederman, L.E., Wimmer, A. and Min, B., 2010. Why do ethnic groups rebel? New data and analysis. *World politics*, 62(1), pp.87-119.

Toft, Monica Duffy, and Yuri M. Zhukov. "Islamists and nationalists: Rebel motivation and counterinsurgency in Russia's North Caucasus." *American Political Science Review* 109, no. 2 (2015): 222-238.

Weidmann N. 2011. Violence "from above" or "from below"? The role of ethnicity in Bosnia's civil war. *Journal of Politics. Politics* 73:41178–90

Recommended:

De Figueiredo Jr, Rui JP, and Barry R. Weingast. "Vicious cycles: Endogenous political extremism and political violence." (2001).

Fearon, J.D. and Laitin, D.D., 2011. Sons of the soil, migrants, and civil war. *World Development*, 39(2), pp.199-211.

Collier, Paul, and Anke Hoeffler. "Greed and Grievance in Civil War." *Oxford Economic Papers* 56, no. 4 (2004): 563-595.

Cederman, Lars-Erik, Kristian Skrede Gleditsch, and Halvard Buhaug. *Inequality, grievances, and civil war.* Cambridge University Press, 2013. Chapters 4 and 5

Barbara Walter *Reputation and Civil War: Why Separatist Conflicts Are So Violent* Cambridge University Press

3. Natural Resources and Civil Wars (Sep 30)

Ross, Michael L. "What Have We Learned About the Resource Curse?." *Annual Review of Political Science* 18, no. 1 (2015): 239-259.

Blair, Graeme, Darin Christensen, and Aaron Rudkin. "Do commodity price shocks cause armed conflict? A meta-analysis of Natural Experiments." *American Political Science Review* 115, no. 2 (2021): 709-716.

Rigterink A. 2020. Diamonds: rebel's and farmer's best friend. Impact of variation in the price of a lootable, labour-intensive natural resource on the intensity of violent conflict. *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 64:190–126

Recommended:

Berman Nicolas, Couttenier Mathieu, Rohner Dominic, Thoenig Mathias. 2017. "This Mine Is Mine! How Minerals Fuel Conflicts in Africa." *American Economic Review* 107 (6): 1564–610

Bazzi Samuel, Blattman Christopher. 2014. "Economic Shocks and Conflict: Evidence from Commodity Prices." *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics* 6:1–38.

Humphreys, M., 2005. Natural resources, conflict, and conflict resolution: Uncovering the mechanisms. *Journal of conflict resolution*, 49(4), pp.508-537.

Dube, O., & Vargas, J. F. (2013). Commodity price shocks and civil conflict: Evidence from Colombia. *The Review of Economic Studies*, 80(4), 1384-1421.

Blair, Graeme, Christensen, Darin and Gibilisco, Michael (2024) "The Point of Attack: when and why does oil cause armed conflict in Africa?" Working Paper

Christensen, Darin. "Concession stands: How mining investments incite protest in Africa." *International organization* 73, no. 1 (2019): 65-101.

Fearon, James D. "Primary commodity exports and civil war." *Journal of conflict Resolution* 49, no. 4 (2005): 483-507.

4. The International Order (Oct 2)

Kalyvas, Stathis N., and Laia Balcells. "International system and technologies of rebellion: How the end of the Cold War shaped internal conflict." *American Political Science Review* 104, no. 3 (2010): 415-429.

Stanton JA. 2020. Rebel groups, international humanitarian law, and civil war outcomes in the post-Cold War era. *International Organization.* 74:3523–59

Karreth, Johannes, Jaroslav Tir, Jason Quinn, and Madhav Joshi. "Civil war mediation in the shadow of IGOs: The path to comprehensive peace agreements." *Journal of Peace Research* 62, no. 2 (2025): 433-447.

Recommended:

Matanock, A. M. (2017). Bullets for ballots: Electoral participation provisions and enduring peace after civil conflict. *International Security*, *41*(4), 93-132.

Matanock, Aila M. "How international actors help enforce domestic deals." *Annual Review of Political Science* 23, no. 1 (2020): 357-383.

5. Rebel Governance (Oct 7)

Arjona, Ana. *Rebelocracy.* Cambridge University Press, 2016. (chapters 1-3)

Sánchez De La Sierra, R., 2020. "On the Origins of the State: Stationary Bandits and Taxation in Eastern Congo." *Journal of Political Economy*, 128(1)

Olson, Mancur. "Dictatorship, Democracy, and Development." *American Political Science Review* 87, no. 3 (1993): 567-576.

Recommended:

Popkin, Samuel. "The rational peasant. Berkeley." *Cal.: Berkeley University Press* (1979).

Arjona, Ana, Nelson Kasfir, and Zachariah Mampilly, eds. *Rebel governance in civil war.* Cambridge University Press, 2015.

6. No class (Movie) Oct 9

7. Rebels and their Organizations (Oct 14)

Jeremy Weinstein. 2006. *Inside Rebellion: The Politics of Insurgent Violence* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press) Chapters 1-2

Hoover Green A. 2016. "The commander's dilemma: creating and controlling armed group violence against civilians". *Journal of Peace Research.* 53:5619–32

Leader Maynard J. 2019. "Ideology and armed conflict". *Journal of Peace Research.* 56:5635–49

Recommended:

Hundman E, Parkinson SE. 2019. Rogues, degenerates, and heroes: disobedience as politics in military organizations. *European Journal of International Relations.* 25:3645–71

Salehyan I, Siroky D, Wood RM 2014. External rebel sponsorship and civilian abuse: a principal-agent analysis of wartime atrocities. *Int. Organ.* 68:3633–61

8. Violence against civilians by the state (Oct 16)

Valentino, B., Huth, P. and Balch-Lindsay, D., 2004. "Draining the sea": mass killing and guerrilla warfare. *International organization*, 58(2), pp.375-407.

Kocher, Matthew Adam, Thomas B. Pepinsky, and Stathis N. Kalyvas. "Aerial bombing and counterinsurgency in the Vietnam War." *American Journal of Political Science* 55, no. 2 (2011): 201-218.

Lyall, Jason. "Does indiscriminate violence incite insurgent attacks? Evidence from Chechnya." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 53, no. 3 (2009): 331-362.

Recommended:

Tucker, Colin. "The effect of aerial bombardment on insurgent civilian victimization." *Security Studies* 30, no. 3 (2021): 450-483.

Wood RM, Kathman JD. 2011. Managing threat, cost, and incentive to kill: the short- and long-term effects of intervention in mass killings. *J. Confl. Resolut.* 55:5735–60

9. Violence against civilians by rebels (Oct 21)

Kalyvas, Stathis N. "Wanton and senseless? The Logic of Massacres in Algeria." *Rationality and Society* 11, no. 3 (1999): 243-285.

Laia Balcells, "Rivalry and Revenge: Violence against Civilians in Conventional Civil Wars," *International Studies Quarterly* 54, no. 2 (2010): 291–313

Wood, Elisabeth Jean. "Rape as a Practice of War: Toward a Typology of Political Violence." *Politics & Society* 46, no. 4 (2018): 513-537.

Lichtenheld A. 2020. Explaining population displacement strategies in civil wars: a cross-national analysis. *International Organization.* 74:2253–94

Recommended:

Gutiérrez-Sanín, Francisco, and Elisabeth Jean Wood. "What should we mean by "pattern of political violence"? Repertoire, targeting, frequency, and technique." *Perspectives on Politics* 15, no. 1 (2017): 20-41.

Nordås, Ragnhild, and Dara Kay Cohen. "Conflict-related sexual violence." *Annual Review of Political Science* 24, no. 1 (2021): 193-211.

Gilbert, Danielle. "The logic of kidnapping in civil war: Evidence from Colombia." *American Political Science Review* 116, no. 4 (2022): 1226-1241.

Balcells, Laia, and Jessica A. Stanton. "Violence against civilians during armed conflict: Moving beyond the macro- and micro-level divide." *Annual Review of Political Science* 24, no. 1 (2021): 45-69.

10. Psychological Sources of Violence (October 23)

Steven Pinker *The Better Angels of Our Nature* Viking Pinguin (2011) (Chapters 8-9)

Littman, Rebecca, and Elizabeth Levy Paluck. "The cycle of violence: Understanding individual participation in collective violence." *Political Psychology* 36 (2015): 79-99.

Luft, Aliza. "Toward a dynamic theory of action at the micro level of genocide: Killing, desistance, and saving in 1994 Rwanda." *Sociological Theory* 33, no. 2 (2015): 148-172.

Haer, Roos, Lilli Banholzer, Thomas Elbert, and Roland Weierstall. "Analyzing the microfoundations of human violence in the DRC-intrinsic and extrinsic rewards and the prediction of appetitive aggression." *Conflict and health* 7, no. 1 (2013): 11.

Recommended:

Elizur Y, Yishay-Krien N. 2009. Participation in atrocities among Israeli soldiers during the first intifada: a qualitative analysis. *Journal of Peace Research.* 46:2251–67

11. Organized Crime (Oct 28)

Barnes, Nicholas. (2017). "Criminal Politics: An Integrated Approach to the Study of Organized Crime, Politics, and Violence." *Perspectives on Politics* , 15 (4), 967-987

Snyder, Richard, and Angélica Durán Martínez. "Drugs, Violence, and State-Sponsored Protection Rackets in Mexico and Colombia." Colombia Internacional 70 (2009): 61-91.

Benjamin Lessing. 2015. "Logics of Violence in Criminal War." *Journal of Conflict Resolution.*

Recommended:

Stathis Kalyvas. 2015. "How Civil Wars Help Explain Organized Crime – and How They Do Not." Journal of Conflict Resolution.

Gambetta, D. (1996). *The Sicilian Mafia: the Business of Private Protection.* Harvard University Press.

Steven D. Levitt and Sudhir Venkatesh. 2000. "An Economic Analysis of a Drug-Selling Gang's Finances." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics 115 (3): 755-789.*

Murphy, Tommy E., and Martín A. Rossi. (2019). "Following the Poppy Trail: Origins and Consequences of Mexican Drug Cartels." *Journal of Development Economics.*

Durán-Martínez, Angélica. "To kill and Tell? State Power, Criminal Competition, and Drug Violence." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 59, no. 8 (2015): 1377-1402.

Grillo, Ioan. *El Narco: Inside Mexico's criminal insurgency*. Bloomsbury Publishing USA, 2012.

12. No Class - Movie (October 30)

13. Democracy Day (Nov 4) No class

14. Dispersing Criminal Violence Across Borders (Nov 6)

Dube, Arindrajit, Oeindrila Dube, and Omar García-Ponce. "Cross-border spillover: US gun laws and violence in Mexico." *American Political Science Review* 107, no. 3 (2013): 397-417

Sviatschi, Maria Micaela. "Spreading gangs: Exporting US criminal capital to El Salvador." *American Economic Review* 112, no. 6 (2022): 1985-2024.

Castillo, Juan Camilo, Daniel Mejía, and Pascual Restrepo. "Scarcity without leviathan: The violent effects of cocaine supply shortages in the Mexican drug war." *Review of Economics and Statistic*s 102, no. 2 (2020): 269-286.

15. In class presentations (first group) (Nov 11)

16. Criminal Governance (Nov 13)

Magaloni, Beatriz, Edgar Franco and Vanessa Melo "Killing in the Slums: Criminal Governance, Social Order and Police Violence in Rio de Janeiro, *American Political Science Review*, 2020

Lessing, Benjamin, and Graham Denyer Willis. "Legitimacy in criminal governance: Managing a drug empire from behind bars." *American Political Science Review* 113, no. 2 (2019): 584-606

Recommended:

Lessing, Benjamin. "Conceptualizing criminal governance." *Perspectives on politics* 19, no. 3 (2021): 854-873.

Feldmann, Andreas E., and Juan Pablo Luna. "Criminal governance and the crisis of contemporary Latin American states." *Annual Review of Sociology* 48 (2022): 441-461.

Blattman, Christopher, Gustavo Duncan, Benjamin Lessing, and Santiago Tobón. "Gang rule: Understanding and countering criminal governance." *Review of Economic Studies* 92, no. 3 (2025): 1497-1531.

17. Government responses to organized crime (Nov 18)

Blair, Robert A., Lucía Mendoza-Mora, and Michael Weintraub. "Mano dura: An experimental evaluation of military policing in Cali, Colombia." *American Journal of Political Science* (2021).

Calderón, Gabriela, Gustavo Robles, Alberto Díaz-Cayeros, and Beatriz Magaloni. "The

Beheading of Criminal Organizations and the Dynamics of Violence in Mexico." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 59, no. 8 (2015): 1455-1485.

Flores-Macías, Gustavo A., and Jessica Zarkin. "The Militarization of Law Enforcement: Evidence from Latin America." *Perspectives on Politics* 19, no. 2 (2021): 519-538.

Mummolo, Jonathan. "Militarization fails to enhance police safety or reduce crime but may harm police reputation." *Proceedings of the national academy of sciences* 115, no. 37 (2018): 9181-9186.
Recommended:

Melissa Dell, "Trafficking Networks and the Mexican Drug War", American Economic Review, vol 105, no. 6 (2015): 1739-79.

Lessing, Benjamin. *Making Peace in Drug Wars: Crackdowns and Cartels in Latin America*. Cambridge University Press, 2017.

18. Police Violence (Nov 20)

GBD 2019 Police Violence US Subnational Collaborators. "Fatal police violence by race and state in the USA, 1980–2019: a network meta-regression." *The Lancet* 398, no. 10307 (2021): 1239-1255.

Magaloni, Beatriz, and Luis Rodriguez. "Institutionalized Police Brutality: Torture, the militarization of security, and the reform of inquisitorial criminal justice in Mexico." *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 4 (2020): 1013-1034.

Magaloni, Beatriz and Esteban Salomón "Fabricated Justice: How Due Process Reform Enables Evidence Manipulation" (R& R World Development)

Soss, Joe, and Vesla Weaver. "Police are our government: Politics, Political Science, and the Policing of Race–Class Subjugated Communities." *Annual Review of Political Science 20*, no. 1 (2017): 565-591

Recommended:

González, Yanilda, and Lindsay Mayka. "Policing, democratic participation, and the reproduction of asymmetric citizenship." *American political science review* 117, no. 1 (2023): 263-279.

Soss, Joe, and Vesla Weaver. "Police are our government: Politics, Political Science, and the Policing of Race–Class Subjugated Communities." *Annual Review of Political Science 20*, no. 1 (2017): 565-591

Weaver, Vesla M. "Policing narratives and the black counterpublic." *The Ethics of Policing: New Perspectives on Law Enforcement* (2021): 149-78.

Knox, Dean, Will Lowe, and Jonathan Mummolo. "Administrative records mask racially biased policing." *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 3 (2020): 619-637.

González, Yanilda María. *Authoritarian police in democracy: Contested security in Latin America*. Cambridge University Press, 2020.

Ba, Bocar A., Dean Knox, Jonathan Mummolo, and Roman Rivera. "The role of officer race and gender in police-civilian interactions in Chicago." *Science* 371, no. 6530 (2021): 696-702.

Knox, Dean, and Jonathan Mummolo. "Making inferences about racial disparities in police violence." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 117, no. 3 (2020): 1261-1262.

THANKSGIVING

19. Legacies of political Violence (Dec 2)

Lupu, Noam, and Leonid Peisakhin. "The legacy of political violence across generations." *American Journal of Political Science* 61, no. 4 (2017): 836-851.

Rozenas, Arturas, Sebastian Schutte, and Yuri Zhukov. "The political legacy of violence: The long-term impact of Stalin's repression in Ukraine." *The Journal of Politics* 79, no. 4 (2017): 1147-1161.

De Juan, Alexander, Christian Gläßel, Felix Haass, and Adam Scharpf. "The political effects of witnessing state atrocities: Evidence from the Nazi death marches." *Comparative Political Studies* (2023): 00104140231178736.

De Juan, Alexander, Felix Haass, Carlo Koos, Sascha Riaz, and Thomas Tichelbaecker. "War and nationalism: How WW1 battle deaths fueled civilians' support for the Nazi Party." *American Political Science Review* 118, no. 1 (2024): 144-162.

Recommended:

Davenport, Christian, Håvard Mokleiv Nygård, Hanne Fjelde, and David Armstrong. "The consequences of contention: Understanding the aftereffects of political conflict and violence." *Annual Review of Political Science* 22, no. 1 (2019): 361-377.

Wood EJ. 2008. The social processes of civil war: the wartime transformation of social networks. *Annu. Rev. Political Sci.* 11:539–61

Costalli S, Ruggeri A. 2015. Forging political entrepreneurs. Civil war effects on post-conflict politics in Italy. *Political Geogr* 44:40–49

Hadzic D, Carlson D, Tavits M 2020. How exposure to violence affects ethnic voting. *Brit. J. Political Sci.* 50:1345–62

Rapp C, Kijewski S, Freitag M 2019. The tolerance of Tamils: war-related experiences, psychological pathways, and the probability of granting civil liberties to former enemies. *J. Politics* 81:41328–41

Blattman, Christopher. "From violence to voting: War and political participation in Uganda." *American political Science review* 103, no. 2 (2009): 231-247.

20. In-class presentations (second group) (Dec 4)